Epilogue

Narendra Modi was sworn in as India’s fifteenth prime minister—and the first to be born after Independence—on 26 May 2014, dressed in a cream kurta and brown sleeveless jacket. The swearing-in ceremony had a typica l Modi touch. Rather than holding it in the stuffy Durbar Hall which can barely accommodate 500 guests, Modi chose the grand forecourt of the Rashtrapati Bhavan for the occasion. Rajpath was lit up—it was a public spectacle played out on live television. The professional event managers in Team Modi were told to work closely with the Rashtrapati Bhavan to ensure that the ceremony went off flawlessly. Clearly, the new prime minister wasn’t convinced that the government officials alone would get it right!

In his moment of ultimate triumph, the guest list suggested a genuine attempt at appearing inclusive. More than 3000 invites were sent out—I received one as well, though, sadly, being in the studio, I couldn’t attend. But many of Modi’s election rivals were present—Sonia and Rahul Gandhi were in attendance, as was Mulayam Singh Yadav. His former mentor L.K. Advani, too, was there. Only days earlier, an emotional Modi had wept in Parliament’s central hall while formally accepting his party’s leadership; Advani had cried as well. It seemed for a fleeting moment like a tearful reunion of the old and new orders within the BJP parivar.

The election campaign had seen the Ambani–Adani duo being targeted as beneficiaries of Modi’s largesse—unmindful of the criticism, both families were there in full strength. Modi hadn’t forgotten his Hindutva roots—sants and sadhus and even the controversial Sadhvi Rithambhara made a rare public appearance. The Hindi film industry was represented by Salman Khan who had flown kites with Modi in Gujarat as part of a PR blitz. And cricket legend Sunil Gavaskar was there in his capacity as BCCI’s interim